

LESSON 2

The Narrative Present: Participles and Enclitics

SECTION 1: REVIEW OF LESSON 1

Quick Summary

In Lesson 1, we established the basic building blocks of Syriac syntax. We learned that Syriac sentences do not strictly require a “to be” verb; rather, placing a subject and predicate side-by-side with a matching independent pronoun acts as an equational sentence (e.g., *Malkā hū ṭābā* — “The king [is] good”). We also looked at the absolute versus empathic states of nouns, with the emphatic ending in *ā* (Alaph) acting as the default dictionary form.

5-Question Warm-Up Drill

(Answers in Section 9)

1. Translate: *Alāhā rabbā hū*.
 2. What is the Syriac absolute state for “word” (from *meltā*)?
 3. How do you say “We” in Syriac?
 4. What particle is used to express “of”, “who”, or “that”?
 5. In *Malkūtā d-Alāhā hī*, why is the pronoun *hī* (she) used instead of *hū* (he)?
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SECTION 2: THE PARTICIPLE AS PRESENT TENSE — OVERVIEW

In Indo-European languages like English, and Greek, the “present tense” is a fully conjugated finite verb (e.g., “I walk”, *περιπατῶ*). Participles are verbal adjectives (e.g., “the *walking* man”).

In Aramaic and Syriac, the **active participle** stepped in to take over the function of the present tense almost entirely. A Syriac speaker didn’t say “I write” as a finite verb; they literally said “Writing [am] I.”

Cross-Linguistic Comparison

- **Hebrew:** Biblical Hebrew primarily used the Imperfect for ongoing action, but by the Mishnaic period (interfacing with Aramaic), Hebrew also adopted the participle for the present tense (e.g., *ānī kōtēb* = I am writing).

- **Arabic:** Standard Arabic relies on the imperfect prefix conjugation (يَكْتُبُ *yaktubu*, “he writes”). The active participle (كَاتِبٌ *kātib*) means “writer” or “one who has written,” but does not serve as a primary present tense verb.
 - **Greek:** Syriac’s reliance on the participle to form continuous action heavily influenced how Syriac translators rendered Greek continuous tenses (often translating a Greek present indicative with a Syriac participle + pronoun).
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SECTION 3: THE PEAL ACTIVE PARTICIPLE & ENCLITICS

The Peal Stem

Semitic verbs exist in different “stems” (or binyanim) that modify their meaning. The basic, un-augmented ground-stem is called the **Pearl**. Almost all basic actions occur in the Pearl.

Forming the Participle

For a strong tri-consonantal root (C-C-C) like *k-t-b* (write), the active participle is formed by inserting a long *ā* after the first consonant, and an *e* after the second.

- *kāteb* (writing, m.sg.)
- *kātbā* (writing, f.sg.)

Enclitic Pronouns

To turn “writing” into “I am writing,” Syriac attaches an **enclitic** pronoun to the back of the participle. Enclitics are shortened, rhythmic versions of the independent pronouns from Lesson 1.

- *'enā* (I) → *-nā*
 - *kāteb* + *-nā* = *kāteb-nā* (I am writing)
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SECTION 4: PARTICIPLE AND ENCLITIC PARADIGMS

1. The Enclitic Pronoun Set

PERSON	INDEPENDENT	ENCLITIC FORM	ATTACHED EXAMPLE (<i>KĀTEB</i>)	TRANSLATION
1 c.sg.	'enā	-nā	kāteb-nā / kātbā-nā	I am writing
2 m.sg.	'ant	-t	kāteb-t	You (m) are writing
2 f.sg.	'anti	-tī	kātbā-tī	You (f) are writing
3 m.sg.	hū	-hū / (none)*	kāteb / kāteb-hū	He is writing / writes
3 f.sg.	hī	-hī / (none)*	kātbā / kātbā-hī	She is writing / writes
1 c.pl.	ḥnan	-ḥnan	kātbīn-ḥnan / kātbān-ḥnan	We are writing
2 m.pl.	'antūn	-tūn	kātbīn-tūn	You (m.pl) are writing
2 f.pl.	'antēn	-tēn	kātbān-tēn	You (f.pl) are writing
3 m.pl.	hennōn	(none)**	kātbīn	They (m) are writing
3 f.pl.	hennēn	(none)**	kātbān	They (f) are writing

**In the 3rd person singular, the participle often stands entirely alone without an enclitic. **In the 3rd person plural, the plural suffix (-īn / -ān) is sufficient; no enclitic is added.*

2. The Peal Active Participle Declension (Root **k-t-b**)

GENDER/NUM	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION
Masc. Sg.	כּתב	kāteb
Fem. Sg.	כתב	kātbā
Masc. Pl.	כתבין	kātbīn
Fem. Pl.	כתבן	kātbān

SECTION 5: SENTENCE SYNTAX

When the active participle drives the sentence, the word order is very fluid, but Verb-Subject-Object (VSO) or Subject-Verb-Object (SVO) are both common.

- **SVO:** *Yūḥannan kāteb meltā.* (Yukhannan writes a word).
- **VSO:** *Kāteb Yūḥannan meltā.* (Writes Yukhannan a word).
- **Enclitic:** *Kāteb-nā meltā.* (I am writing a word).

SECTION 6: VOCABULARY (STRONG VERBS & ADVERBS)

ROOT	PEAL PTCP (M.S.)	MEANING	ADVERB/PARTICLE	MEANING
כ.ת.ב	kāteb	to write	כַּעַתָּה (hāšā)	now
א.ל.ך	ʾāzel	to go	דֵּן (dēn)	but, then, however
א.מ.ר	ʾāmer	to speak/say	תַּמָּאֵן (tammān)	there
ש.מ.ע	šāmaʿ *	to hear	לְעֵל (lʿel)	above
ר.א.ו	hāzē	to see	הֵכָּא (harkā)	here
ע.ב.ד	ʿābed	to do/make	עִמָּ (ʿam)	with
נ.צ.ר	nāṭer	to keep/guard	עַל (ʿal)	upon, against
ר.ד.פ	rādep	to pursue		
ש.ב.ע	šābeq	to leave		
נ.פ.ע	nāpeq	to go out		

*Note: Roots ending in gutturals (like ʿ Ayn) change the **e** to an **a** (šāmaʿ instead of šāmeʿ).

SECTION 7: THE STORY — PART 2

Preparation

Narrative note: The present tense (participle + enclitics) is used here to create an immediate, action-oriented dialogue as Yukhannan prepares his disciples.

Sentence 1

לח אהא אהא אהא אהא אהא אהא Yūḥannan 'āmer l-talmīdē d-īt l-eh. Yūḥannan (John) 'āmer (is-speaking) l- (to) talmīdē (the-disciples) d- (that) īt (there-are) l-eh (to-him). → Yukhannan is speaking to the disciples that are his.

Sentence 2

אהא אהא אהא אהא אהא אהא 'āzel-nā men harkā. 'āzel (going) -nā (am-I) men (from) harkā (here). → “I am going from here.”

Sentence 3

אהא אהא אהא אהא אהא אהא 'āzel-nā l-malkūtā d-bīšā, 'āmer-hū. 'āzel (going) -nā (am-I) l- (to) malkūtā (the-kingdom) d- (of) bīšā (the-evil-[one]), 'āmer (says) -hū (he). → “I am going to the kingdom of the evil one,” he says.

Sentence 4

אהא אהא אהא אהא אהא אהא talmīdē šām 'īn meltā d-Yūḥannan. talmīdē (the-disciples) šām 'īn (are-hearing) meltā (the-word) d- (of) Yūḥannan (John). → The disciples hear the word of Yukhannan.

Sentence 5

אהא אהא אהא אהא אהא אהא hennōn 'āmrīn: ḥāzēn-ḥnan malkā bīšā tammān. hennōn (they) 'āmrīn (are-saying): ḥāzēn (seeing) -ḥnan (are-we) malkā (a-king) bīšā (evil) tammān (there). → They say: “We see an evil king there.”

Sentence 6

אהא אהא אהא אהא אהא אהא Yūḥannan 'ābed nūhrā b-'ar 'ā. Yūḥannan (John) 'ābed (is-making/doing) nūhrā (light) b- (in) 'ar 'ā (the-earth). → Yukhannan makes light in the earth.

Sentence 7

אהא אהא אהא אהא אהא אהא kāteb-nā meltā d-Alāhā, 'āmer hāšā. kāteb (writing) -nā (am-I) meltā (the-word) d- (of) Alāhā (God), 'āmer (says-[he]) hāšā (now). → “I am writing the word of God,” he says now.

SECTION 8: EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Participle Identification

Identify the gender and number of the following participles.

1. ܕܠܒܝܢ (kātbin)
2. ܫܡܐܐ (šām ‘ ā)
3. ܢܦܩܐܢ (nāpqān)
4. ܪܕܦܐ (rādep)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill

Combine the root ‘-b-d (to do, make) with the correct enclitic pronoun to form the present tense for:

1. I am making (m.sg)
2. We are making (m.pl)
3. You (f.sg) are making
4. They (m.pl) are making.

Exercise 3: Translation Drill (Syriac → English)

Translate the following present tense clauses.

1. ‘āzel-nā l-malkūtā.
2. Šām ‘īn-tūn meltā d-Alāhā.
3. Barnāšā bīšā rādep l-Yūḥannan.
4. Ḥāzēn-ḥnan nūhrā rabbā tammān.

Exercise 4: Production Drill (English → Syriac)

Render the following active present sentences into Syriac transliteration.

1. I (m) am hearing the word.
2. She is writing a good word.
3. They (m) are going from here.
4. You (m.pl) are seeing the king.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

Re-read Section 7 and answer:

1. From where does Yūkhannan say he is going?
 2. What do the disciples fear they will see there?
 3. What is Yūkhannan “writing” right now?
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SECTION 9: ANSWER KEY

Section 1 Warm-Up

1. God is great.
2. *Melt* (ܡܠܬ)
3. *ḥnan*
4. *d-*
5. Because *malkūtā* (kingdom) is a feminine noun.

Exercise 1: Participle Identification

1. Masculine Plural
2. Feminine Singular
3. Feminine Plural
4. Masculine Singular

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill

1. ‘ābed-nā
2. ‘ābdīn-ḥnan
3. ‘ābdā-tī
4. ‘ābdīn (no enclitic needed for 3rd person pl)

Exercise 3: Translation Drill

1. I am going to the kingdom.
2. You all are hearing the word of God.
3. The evil man is pursuing Yūkhannan.
4. We are seeing a great light there.

Exercise 4: Production Drill

1. Šāma^ʿ -nā meltā.
2. Kātbā meltā ṭābtā.
3. ʾĀzlīn men harkā.
4. Ḥāzēn-tūn l-malkā.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

1. “From here” (*men harkā*).
2. An evil king (*malkā bīšā*).
3. The word of God (*meltā d-Alāhā*).

SECTION 10: GRAMMATICAL SUMMARY

PARTICIPLE + ENCLITIC COMBINATIONS (Masc. Root k-t-b)

ENGLISH	PARTICIPLE	ENCLITIC	COMBINED SYRIAC FORM
I write (m)	kāteb	-nā	kāteb-nā
You write (m)	kāteb	-t	kāteb-t
He writes	kāteb	(-hū)	kāteb / kāteb-hū
We write (m)	kātbīn	-ḥnan	kātbīn-ḥnan
You all write (m)	kātbīn	-tūn	kātbīn-tūn
They write (m)	kātbīn	(none)	kātbīn

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following 30 genuinely new high-frequency words supplement this lesson's vocabulary, focusing on

nouns and derived verbal nouns relevant to narrative present (participle) usage.

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܫܒܬܐ	šabbtā	f. noun	sabbath, week	pl. šabbē
ܠܒܫܐ	lbūšā	m. noun	garment, clothing	from root l-b-š (to wear)
ܕܟܪܢܐ	dəkrānā	m. noun	memory, remembrance	from root d-k-r (to remember)
ܩܥܐ	peg‘ā	m. noun	encounter, accident	from root p-g-‘ (to meet)
ܫܒܥܐ	šeb‘ā	f. noun	finger	body part
ܩܠܬܐ	pūlhānā	m. noun	labor, toil	from root p-l-ḥ (to serve)
ܢܬܪܐ	nāṭōrtā	f. noun	guard, watchfulness	from root n-ṭ-r (to guard)
ܕܡܠܬܐ	gəməlūtā	f. noun	kindness, mercy	from root g-m-l (to treat well)
ܠܒܟܐ	lebḵātā	f. noun	capture, grasping	from root l-b-k (to hold)
ܡܫܟܢܐ	meskēnūtā	f. noun	poverty, want	abstract noun
ܩܠܬܐ	pəlgūtā	f. noun	division, share	from root p-l-g (to divide)
ܩܠܬܐ	qəlpəttā	f. noun	shell, exterior	
ܪܒܐ	rugzā	m. noun	rage, wrath	from root r-g-z (to be angry)
ܝܕܐ	īdā‘tā	f. noun	knowledge	from root y-d-‘ (to know)
ܩܦܪܐ	kəprā	m. noun	village, hamlet	place noun
ܩܦܪܐ	pəqrā	m. noun	opening, aperture	from root p-q-r (to open)

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܟܡܝܪܘܬܬܐ	gmīrūtā	f. noun	completion, perfection	from root g-m-r (to complete)
ܟܬܐܢܐ	‘ ūšnā	m. noun	strength, might	from root ‘ -š-n (to be strong)
ܟܬܐܬܐ	šəp ‘ ā	m. noun	abundance, plenty	from root š-p- ‘ (to suffice)
ܟܬܐܠܐ	laḥmā	m. noun	bread, food	staple item
ܟܬܐܡܐ	pəsmā	m. noun	measure, standard	
ܟܬܐܡܬܐ	šəlmūtā	f. noun	completeness, wholeness	from root š-l-m (to be whole)
ܟܬܐܠܩܐ	‘ alqā	m. noun	ascent, stairway	from root ‘ -l-q (to ascend)
ܟܬܐܓܐ	syāgā	m. noun	enclosure, hedge	from root s-w-g (to fence)
ܟܬܐܠܦܐ	šuḥlāpā	m. noun	change, alteration	from root š-ḥ-l-p (to change)
ܟܬܐܠܩܘܬܐ	dəḥīqūtā	f. noun	clinging, adherence	from root d-b-q (to cling)
ܟܬܐܠܫܘܬܐ	qaddīšūtā	f. noun	holiness, sanctity	from root q-d-š (to be holy)
ܟܬܐܠܘܬܐ	gdūlūtā	f. noun	greatness, grandeur	from root g-d-l (to be great)
ܟܬܐܠܝܘܬܐ	‘ arṭlāyūtā	f. noun	nakedness, exposure	from root ‘ -r-ṭ-l (to be naked)
ܟܬܐܠܪܐܐ	dəbrānā	m. noun	leader, governor	related to d-b-r
ܟܬܐܠܡܐ	rawmā	m. noun	height, elevation	from root r-w-m (to be high)